

HEARTBREAK FOR RUSSELL

Ecstasy fizzled into disappointment for the Mercedes driver when stewards found his car 1.5 kg below the minimum weight limit at the end of the Belgium Grand Prix, disqualifying him and handing Lewis Hamilton a dramatic win.

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As the curtains came down on the first half of the Formula One season following the Hungarian and Belgian GP double-header, it capped off an exciting run of races.

The year started with fears of another Red Bull domination, but now three to four teams are evenly matched and capable of fighting for wins depending on track layout and ambient weather conditions.

With little to choose between the teams, the role of the driver and how the team executes its race strategy are proving vital, which has also spiced up the racing.

The big storyline since May has been how Red Bull lost the mighty advantage it enjoyed in the first five races while rivals McLaren and Mercedes caught up to the reigning champion.

The last two races in July showed just that, as McLaren and Mercedes dominated proceedings in Hungary and Belgium, respectively.

The kids are alright

McLaren was at its best at the Hungaroring, locking out the front

row. Lando Norris took pole position ahead of teammate Oscar Piastri, and the team enjoyed a majestic 1-2, its first since 2021. However, due to McLaren's conservative decision-making, it ended up feeling like a pyrrhic victory.

For two-thirds of the race, McLaren controlled the race beautifully. Piastri was in the lead ahead of his teammate Norris, whom he edged at the start. But the race came alive when McLaren decided to shoot itself in the foot with a messy strategy that caused them a lot of grief.

During the second round of stops, McLaren serviced Norris first, going against convention in which the lead driver gets priority in taking fresh rubber. The team said it was to help Norris avoid being undercut by the likes of Lewis Hamilton, though it was